

THE RIGHTS OF EVERY WORKER

THE TRADE UNION ACT (1871)



IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Employment law

BEFORE

1799, 1800 The Combination Acts passed during the Napoleonic Wars make strike action illegal in Britain.

1824 UK Parliament repeals the Combination Acts as the power of trade unions grows.

1868 The Trades Union Congress (TUC) is established in Manchester, in the UK.

AFTER

1886 The American Federation of Labor (AFL), a national federation of craft unions, is founded in Ohio.

1900 The UK Labour Party is established.

1901 The first international trade union organization is established.

1906 The Trade Disputes Act is passed in the UK.

Key legislation passed in the UK in the late 19th and early 20th centuries helped protect trade unions and, as a consequence, shifted the balance of power somewhat in favor of workers and away from employers.

Those who established the first trade unions believed that any worker–employer negotiation is heavily weighted in favor of the employers because they have the economic power and influence. Unless there is a severe skills shortage, the individual worker has very little bargaining power and therefore can easily be